

OCTOBER 2026

LIFTeracy

Lifting children out of learning poverty

A one-on-one AI tutor that teaches government primary school students in India to read Hindi through WhatsApp voice messages.

Watch a 3-minute demo video

Try it out here
(if you know Hindi)

Live metrics

Book a meeting →
Questions? Comments?
Interested in a demo?
We'd love to talk

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

WHAT IT IS

LIFTeracy is a **one-on-one AI tutor** that teaches government primary school students (age 6–10) in India to read Hindi through WhatsApp voice messages, at home on the family phone.

TEAM

Tom Delaney grew up in India and spent **eight years in an Indian education non-profit**, training tens of thousands of government teachers. David Nelson is a **software engineer and serial entrepreneur**.

PROBLEM

Fewer than half of ten-year-olds in India can read. Key reasons are poor pedagogy, lack of individual attention, and lack of practice at home. This represents a huge loss of potential: if 90% could read, India would gain $37 trillion of additional economic growth by 2050 – nine times its 2025 GDP – with 1.3 million fewer child marriages and 420,000 fewer under-five deaths (What Works Hub for Global Education).

SOLUTION

We have adapted the paper-based **Accelerating Learning for All (ALfA)** programme[1] for WhatsApp, to cut cost and keep teaching consistent at scale.

EVIDENCE

LIFTeracy builds on **differentiated learning**, a great buy recommended by the World Bank and endorsed by AIM. A meta-analysis of adaptive EdTech software found effect sizes of **0.35 SD** of learning gains – about 1.5-2 years of normal schooling.

COST-EFFECTIVENESS

A 5-minute lesson costs us **2 cents**. If our assumptions hold at scale, we estimate overall costs of about $16 per child who completes a full 20-hour course, equivalent to roughly **$31 per income doubling or 11x** GiveWell's cash benchmark.

WHY INDIA? WHY HINDI?

Hindi is highly phonetic and has more illiterate native speakers than any other language. 84% of Indian rural households have a smartphone, and over 500 million Indians are on WhatsApp. Our partner organisation has agreements for literacy implementation in four states covering **10 million** government primary school students.

YEAR 1 PLAN

We spent the last year, without institutional funding, building a product that can scale. For the coming year, we are seeking **$196k** to distribute it through partners' government MoUs, focusing on our biggest uncertainties: **engagement and retention**.

ENDGAME

Long term, **we hope that Indian governments will pay LIFTeracy's tech costs in public schools.** This fits current budgets and has precedents.



[1] Accelerating Learning for All (ALfA) is in use across over 10,000 government schools. Tom spent eight years at DEVI Sansthan, which developed ALfA. Six DEVI-run trials found average gains of 0.59 SD, and a Harvard student review found promising but not conclusive results.

FOUNDING TEAM

LIFTeracy was our own idea, inspired by the ALfA pedagogy Tom helped implement. We had been building LIFTeracy for 16 months before joining AIM's Incubation Program.

Tom Delaney →

PEDAGOGY, PROGRAMMES & OPS

- Grew up in India, fluent in Hindi
- Eight years at DEVI Sansthan, an Indian education non-profit
- Trained tens of thousands of government teachers (example)
- Coauthored two books (2022, 2024) and a journal article on literacy
- Based in India, leading operations on the ground



← David Nelson

SOFTWARE, FUNDRAISING & STRATEGY

- Degrees in Physics and Chemical Engineering
- Serial entrepreneur; founded a modular housing company
- Software engineer with Silicon Valley experience.
- Wrote LIFTeracy's open-source code
- Based in Boston, leading software, US networking and fundraising

Advisory panel



PEDAGOGY

Ilana Kessler is Co-Founder and Executive Director of Learning Alliance, a foundational learning NGO scaling structured pedagogy in Uganda. A former teacher, she spent 15+ years leading programmes at One Acre Fund, Precision Development and Evidence Action.



EDTECH

Abdulhamid Haidar, Founder and CEO of Darsel, a global EdTech non-profit improving math learning with government school systems. Its AI-powered personalised learning chatbot has reached over 500,000 students, mainly in Jordan, India and Nigeria.



INDIAN EDUCATION

Natasha Ahuja is Strategy and Innovation Manager at Suvita. She has previously worked with field-leading organisations including the What Works Hub for Global Education, Youth Impact, and Our World in Data.



SCALING EXPERT

Sofia Martinez Galvez is cofounder of Learning Alliance, and now designs models to scale effective education solutions at Tanza Partners. She was a Fulbright Scholar at MIT (master's in Data, Economics and Development Policy).



We also wish to acknowledge & thank:

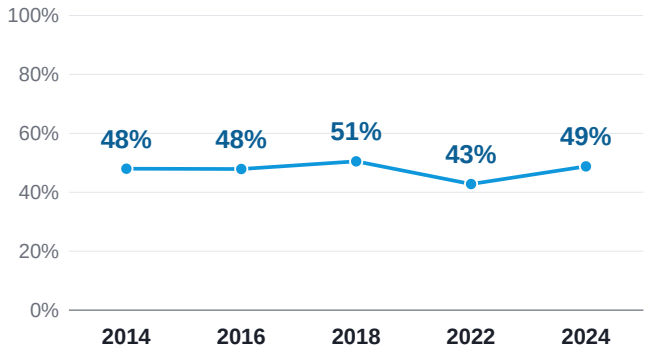
- **Mohan Singh** for his help piloting in Kakori, Lucknow, India;
- **Mr Ramshankar**, **Block Education Officer,** Kakori, for supporting the pilot;
- The many government **Academic Resource Persons (ARPs), teachers** and **students** who have tried it out!

PROBLEM

Most people reading this sentence learnt to read before they were six.
Yet about 70% of children in low- and middle-income countries can't read a simple text by the time they are ten (World Bank).

Reading is the first rung of the educational ladder: **children learn to read, then read to learn.** Children who fall behind often stay behind, and many drop out: across Ethiopia, India, Peru and Vietnam, scoring one standard deviation lower at age 8 doubled the odds of leaving school by age 12 (Kaffenberger, Sobol and Spindelman, 2021). In India, more children now attend school, but learning levels have stagnated for a decade.

% of Grade 5 children who can read a Grade 2 text, India



Dip in 2022 follows Covid school closures. Source: ASER 2024

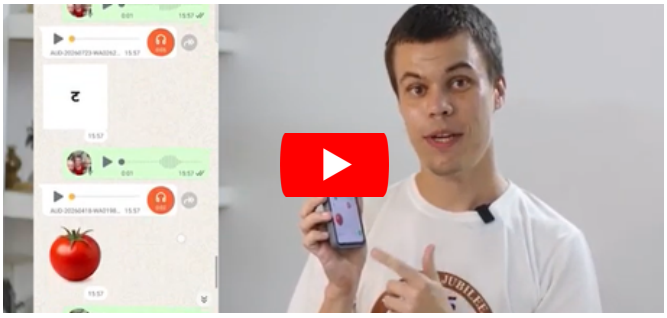
Why do children spend years in school without learning to read?

The causes are complex, but four stand out – and LIFTeracy is designed to address all of them.

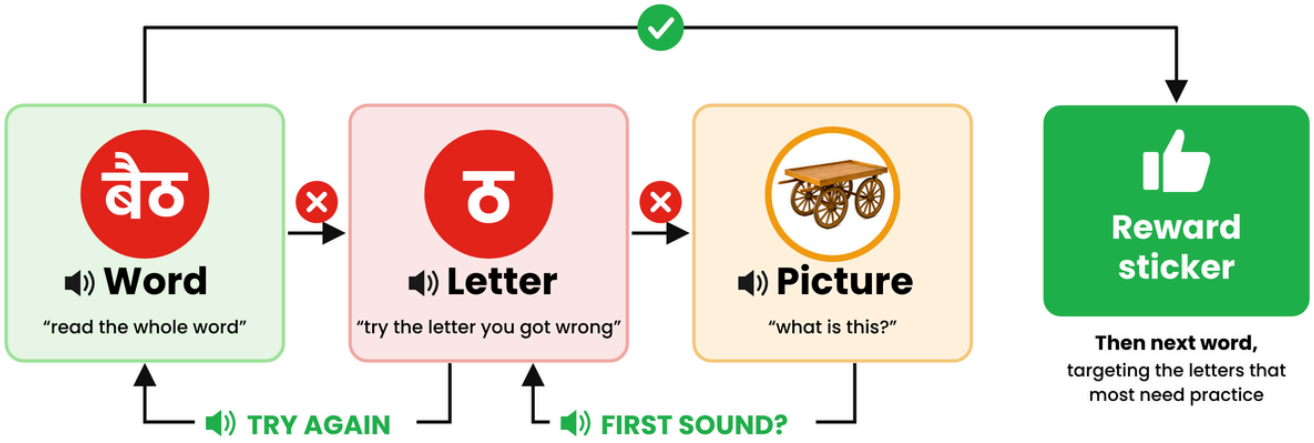
THE PROBLEM	LIFTERACY'S ANSWER
Rote memorisation Students spend much of the day copying from the blackboard and repeating after the teacher (Bhattacharjea et al., 2011).	**Effective pedagogy** LIFTeracy digitises Accelerating Learning for All (ALfA), a picture-based method that asks questions and builds on students' knowledge.
Little individual attention Classes are large and teachers must keep pace with the curriculum; children who fall behind struggle (Muralidharan et al., 2019).	**Personalised learning** The tutor tracks each child's mastery of every letter; children get personalised practice, move at their own pace up to passages & comprehension.
Little practice at home Many children have no literate parent to help: only 66% of women in Uttar Pradesh can read (NFHS-5).	**Practice from home** The tutor is available on WhatsApp at any time, whether or not a child has a literate adult around.
Solutions hard to scale Proven solutions exist – Differentiated Learning, Structured Pedagogy – but are hard to implement with fidelity at scale.	**Scaling with fidelity** Can be scaled up without any watering down of pedagogy, without relying on teachers changing how they teach.

SOLUTION

Children start school knowing thousands of words by ear, just not how they are written. LIFTeracy builds on this. The AI tutor asks the child, by voice on WhatsApp, to read a word; speech-to-text finds any letter they got wrong, and the tutor gives a picture hint. Teachers share the link with students to use at home, and follow progress on dashboards.



Watch a 3-minute product demo video



Why another EdTech solution?

The combination of three aspects sets LIFTeracy apart from most EdTech:

LIFTERACY	MOST EDTECH
Voice-based, covers the full range of literacy skills	Text-heavy, suits children who can already read
Low-friction: runs on WhatsApp, familiar interface	Apps must be downloaded, with sign-ins and permissions
Student-facing: tutors the child directly, without requiring behavioural/pedagogical change in teachers	Some (e.g. Wadhwani AI, Pratham) only assess students; rely on teachers to change how they teach

Explore our interactive comparison with other leading Hindi EdTech solutions.



EVIDENCE

LIFTeracy has no direct high-quality evidence yet beyond internal monitoring. However, it builds on promising evidence for its paper-based equivalent, the strong evidence for differentiated learning, and emerging evidence for similar EdTech and WhatsApp tutors.

1 ALfA pedagogy

- Picture-based phonics programme Tom helped develop with DEVI Sansthan.
- Six trials, 80,000+ students: +0.59 SD in Hindi over about 45 working days (Gandhi and Delaney, 2025).
- A Harvard review found 0.23–0.89 SD but data-quality problems (Liu, Huang and Ben Baz, 2023): promising, not conclusive.

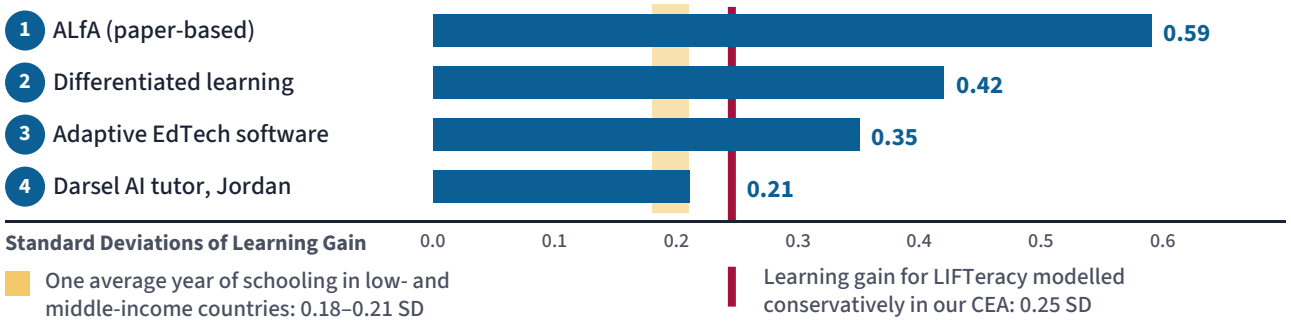
LIFTeracy: digitises ALfA for phones.

2 Differentiated learning

- An education "great buy" (World Bank GEEAP, 2023; AIM).
- Eight programmes: 0.42 SD on average, 0.85 SD with high fidelity (Angrist and Meager, 2023).
- Teacher-led versions struggle with time and fidelity at scale.

LIFTeracy: targets each child's weakest letters at their own pace, automating the assess-and-regroup work.

Learning gains from the approaches LIFTeracy draws on



3 Adaptive EdTech

- EdTech in low- and middle-income countries averages 0.15–0.18 SD (McEwan, 2015; Major et al., 2021).
- Software that adapts to each learner's level: 0.35 SD (Major et al., 2021).

LIFTeracy: adaptive by design, from 2-letter words to passages.

4 AI tutors

- Darsel, WhatsApp maths tutor, Jordan: 0.21 SD (Krafft et al., 2026).
- Rori, Ghana: 0.37 SD (Henkel et al., 2024).
- Copilot, Nigeria: 0.3 SD in six weeks (World Bank, 2025).

LIFTeracy: a WhatsApp AI tutor too, but for early reading in Hindi.

Expert opinion

Aug–Oct 2026: we consulted academics, practitioners, officials and EdTech founders (research report). The general consensus was:

- LIFTeracy is a promising product; the voice-based focus on decoding and blending is excellent.
- The distribution plan – via government schools, using WhatsApp groups – is viable.
- Usage stickiness and user retention are hard for most EdTech and should be a top focus for us.

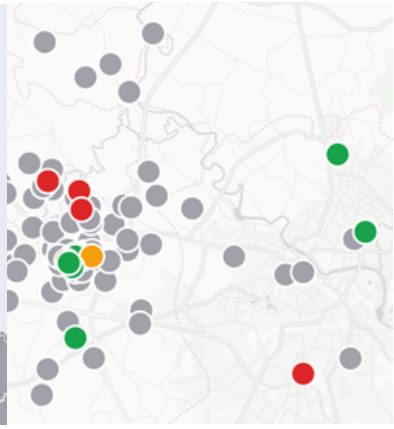
TRACTION SO FAR

2026 has been a product-first year: we moved the tutor from a web app to WhatsApp and released features in small, frequent steps, rather than pushing for scale or measuring learning formally. Usage is still small, but the children who practise most appear to be learning.

Click here to drill down with the live dashboard



State level view



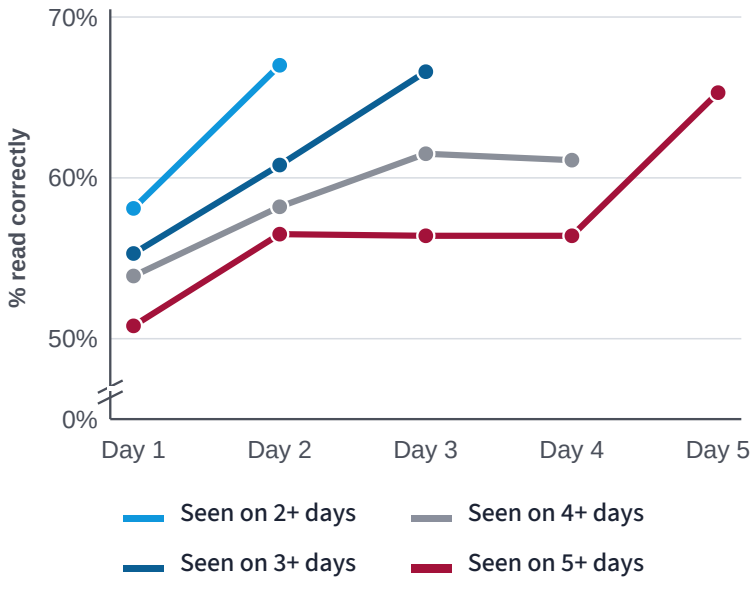
School level view

457 children	306 hours	38 children	18% DAU/MAU
used the WhatsApp tutor, 13 Apr – 30 Oct 2026	of use in total	have done at least 10 five-minute lessons	18% of monthly users active on a typical day in October, up from 5–10% earlier

Usage is growing. October has had 125 hours of tutor usage, more than double previous months (max: 50 hours).

Children appear to be learning to read words.
When the same child met the same word on separate days (1,783 occasions, 98 children), accuracy rose from 58% on Day 1 to 67% on Day 2. For words a child saw on 5 separate days – which tend to contain letters that child finds hard – accuracy rose from 51% to 65% (294 occasions, 37 children).

% of words read correctly, when same child sees the same word on different days

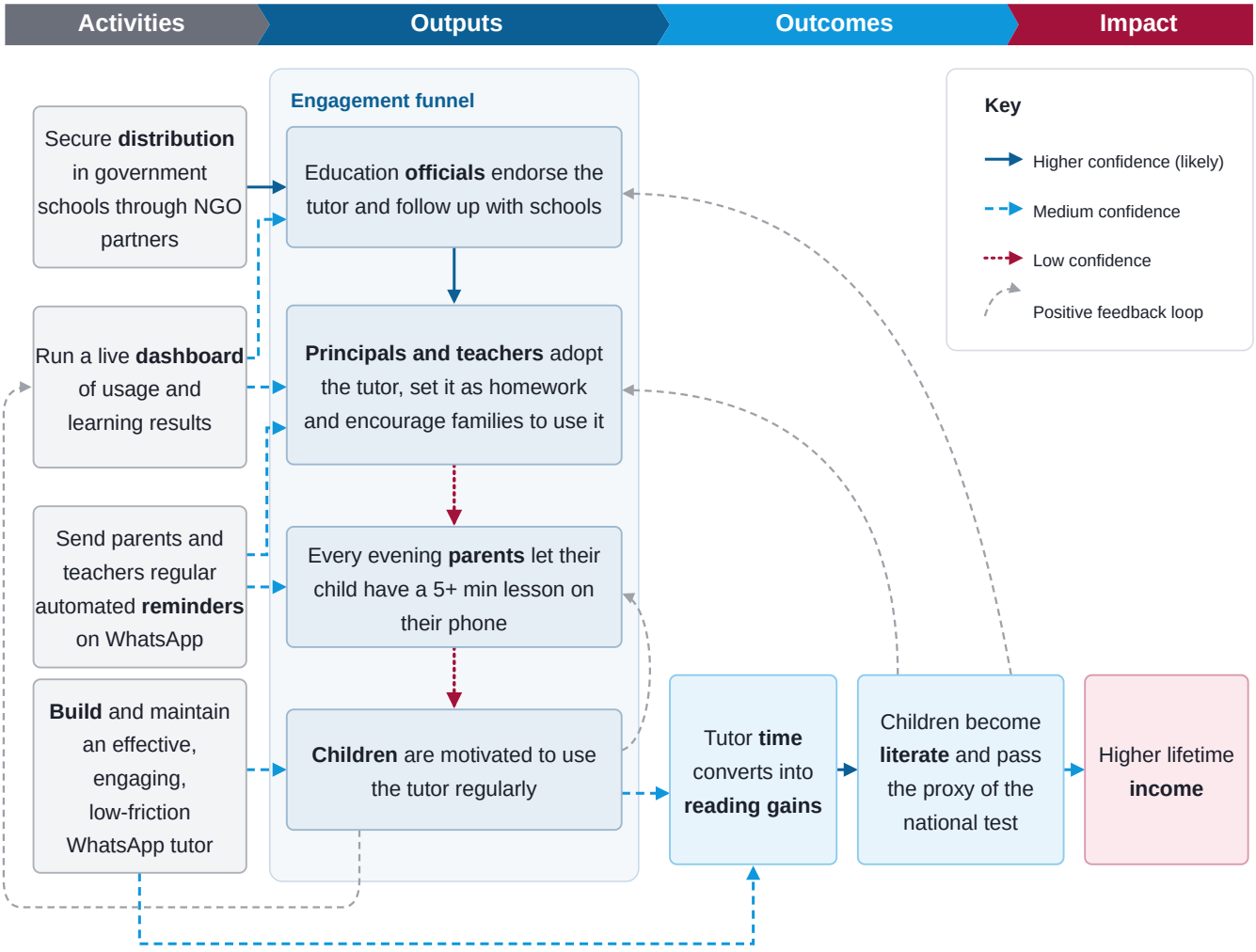


Children appear to improve in reading fluency and comprehension, though sample size is small. Between a child's first and third day of passages, reading speed rose from 77 to 88 correct words per minute (19 children) and comprehension from 53% to 66% (21 children).

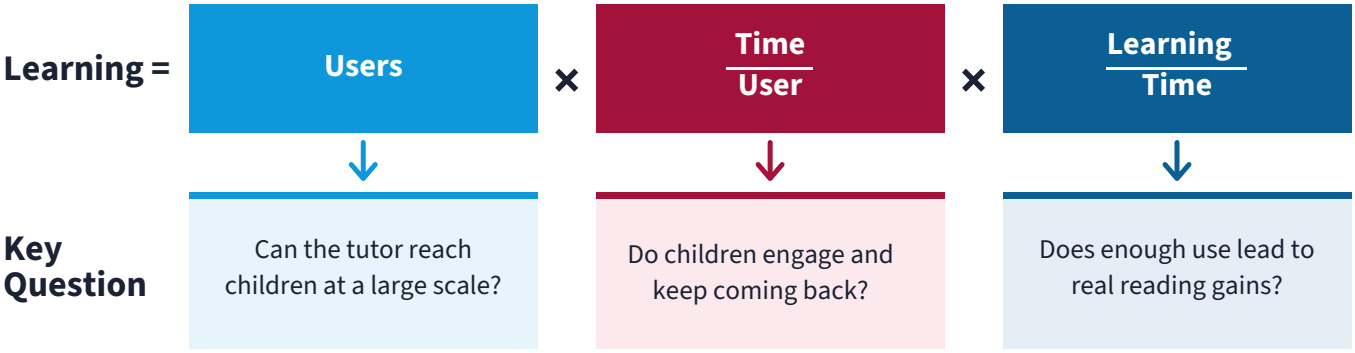
Example student: Rahul (name changed). Since starting on 13 August, Rahul has used LIFTeracy for over 12 hours (about 10 minutes a day). He learnt 8 new letters in his first week, and over three weeks his word accuracy rose from 53% to 67% to 81%. By early October he had reached the top level (150-word passages), answering 66% of comprehension questions correctly.

THEORY OF CHANGE

Our theory of change builds on a promising pedagogy, distribution partners and a school system that already runs on WhatsApp. Explore the evidence and uncertainties in our interactive theory of change.



Our learning impact can be expressed as the product of three terms:



We will focus first on **Time/User**, because (a) we already see early signs of learning gains, and (b) reliable tests to improve Learning/Time need children to already spend enough time on the tutor.

MONITORING, EVALUATION AND LEARNING

Our MEL plan has four steps to test the key uncertainties in our Theory of Change and act on them.

1 Understand what drives engagement

- We will build a picture of the barriers to and enablers of engagement by interviewing children who keep practising and those who stopped after a few days, their parents who have greater or lesser engagement, and teachers who shared the link widely vs not at all.
- We will sample across states, urban and rural schools, and boys and girls.
- Barriers and enablers might include:
  - a child knows the letters but struggles to pronounce them
  - the phone is only at home in the evening, or there is no data recharge
  - fun, pride, or a teacher's praise
- We will then rank each factor by its apparent link to usage and how far we can influence it.

2 A/B test the most promising fixes. For example:

WHAT TO TEST	METRIC FOR SUCCESS
Prizes for top teachers, with a photo shared in local teachers' WhatsApp group	Student usage the following week where teachers (a) receive a prize, (b) attend the ceremony, or (c) are in the WhatsApp group
Phone calls to teachers with low usage	Extra minutes of usage per call vs call cost
Reminders: time of day, frequency, style (e.g. voice vs video)	Total usage time
A 30-minute daily cap (does scarcity bring children back?) vs unlimited use	Total usage time

3 Measure & optimise learning

Once usage stabilises, we will use similar methods to optimise the learning algorithm, tracking progress with short ASER-style tests.

4 Randomised Controlled Trial

Once the tutor is largely optimised and stable, we expect to run an external RCT, likely beyond Year 1. We have begun conceptualising it with J-PAL-affiliated researcher Guthrie Gray-Lobe.





YEAR 1 PLAN

Year 1 (November 2026 to December 2027) has three phases, each answering one key question.

PHASE AND KEY QUESTION	RESEARCH	PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT	SCALE	NOTES
1 **Preparation** Nov–Dec 26 *Why do children stop, and what might keep them?*	Interview children, parents and teachers (see MEL plan).	More engagement features, e.g. usage leaderboard for students.	**~30 schools**	Train part-time DEVI field staff to run small pilots in several states.
2 **A/B testing** Jan–Jun 27 *Which features keep children practising?*	A/B test fixes from the interviews, then learning features such as pace of progression and mix of games.	In-app test proxies, verify against paper-based tests.	**~100 schools**	Expand in Phase 1's most promising geographies. Operations Head joins; hire our own field staff.
3 **Scale and consolidate** Jul–Dec 27 *How to optimise learning as we grow?*	Keep A/B testing; track learning per hour with in-app check-ins. Finalise RCT design.	Deeper learning features, e.g. asking open-ended comprehension questions; asking a child to imagine how a story might finish.	**~500 schools**	Seek district and state permissions, and more NGO partners. Hire more field staff. Fundraise for Year 2.

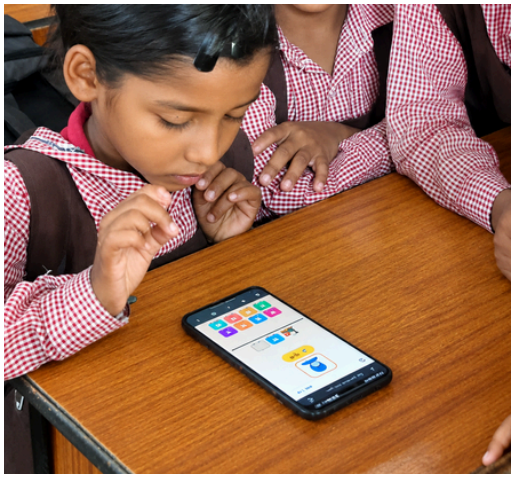
TARGET GEOGRAPHIES	Hindi-speaking areas of Uttar Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Jammu.
TARGET GRADES	Government primary schools (Grades 1–5, ages 6–10)
IMPLEMENTATION & EVALUATION PARTNERS	• DEVI Sansthan brings field teams and government agreements in four states. • We are discussing implementation partnerships with Pratham, Google ReadAlong, Rocket Learning and Wadhwani AI. • J-PAL-affiliated researcher Guthrie Gray-Lobe advises on evaluation design.

See our detailed Year 1 work plan and decision points.

Year 2 and beyond. If the answers from Year 1 are positive, we would prioritise

- Conducting an RCT
- Scaling through DEVI Sansthan while cutting labour-intensive steps (e.g. school calls or visits)
- Expanding partnerships with other NGOs, embedding our pedagogy in their products
- Signing agreements with state governments directly

If Year 1's answers are negative, we would pivot or shut down.



FINANCES

	LEAN	CORE	AMBITIOUS
# months	12	14	14
Cofounder Salaries	$73,200	$85,400	$85,400
Field personnel & local travel	$31,200	$44,600	$66,500
Services (subcontracting software engineering)	$12,000	$21,000	$28,000
Programme supplies (tech subscriptions & per-user tech costs)	$11,500	$18,800	$29,600
International travel	$4,100	$6,500	$6,500
Fiscal sponsorship	$8,200	$10,800	$13,300
Contingency (10% excl Cofounder Salaries & Fiscal Sponsorship)	$5,900	$9,100	$13,100
Total	**$146,100**	**$196,200**	**$242,100**

Key differences between scenarios

Lean ($146,100)

- Both founders, an Operations Head from March, 2 FTE field staff; reaches about 300 schools
- Unlikely to have the RCT design ready for Year 2
- Less extensive interviews of students, parents & teachers; shallower A/B testing
- Slower rollout of new features

Core ($196,200)

- 3 FTE field staff, reaching about 500 schools
- Adds two months, enables more in-depth interviews and greater A/B testing, faster rollout of new features
- Likely to finalise the RCT design for Year 2

Ambitious ($242,100)

- 3 FTE field staff rising to 6 in Phase 3; able to provide more support and work in about 1,000 schools
- Head of Partnerships joining in Phase 3, provides greater ability to engage with district and state-level governments, and a larger set of NGO partners
- Ability to pilot in more different geographies to compare workings of state governments

See our full budget scenarios.



COST-EFFECTIVENESS ANALYSIS

Our cost-effectiveness model estimates $31 per income doubling – about 11x GiveWell's cash benchmark.[2] Our Monte Carlo simulator shows how the result changes with each uncertain input.

$31	11x	75%
per income doubling	GiveWell's cash benchmark	chance of achieving AIM's bar of <$60 per income doubling

Why might LIFTeracy be highly cost-effective?

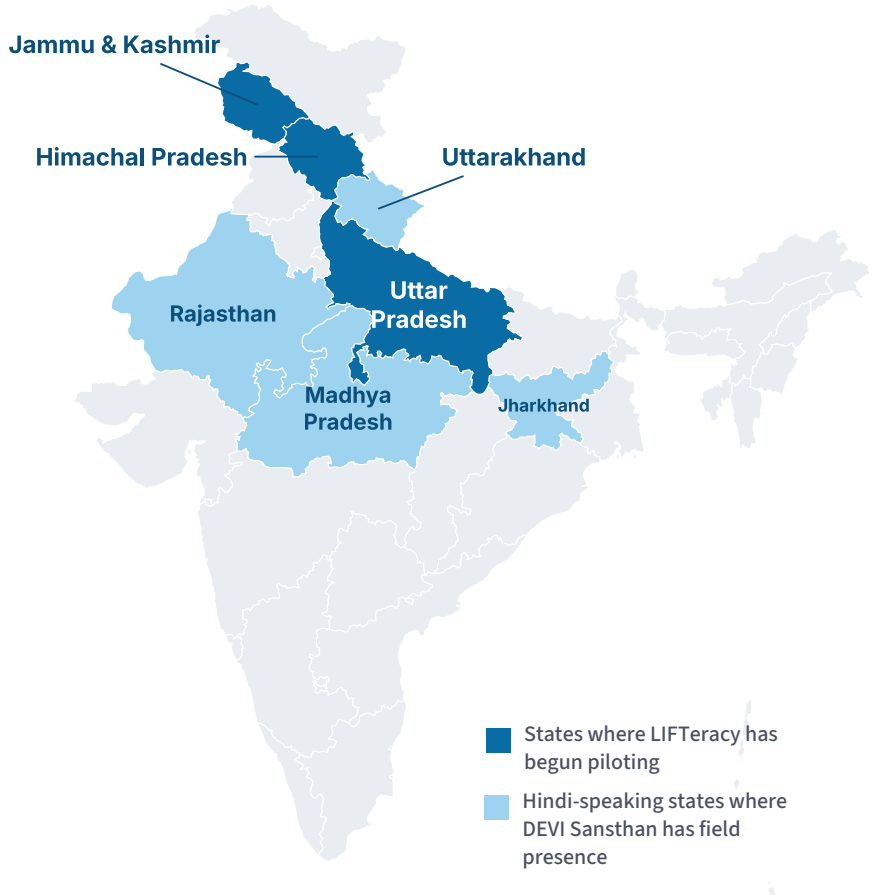
- We aim to pair the **high impact** of differentiated learning with the **low cost** of mass communication.
- Staff are education's biggest cost. We add no teachers; students get automated practice at home.
- We use existing infrastructure (school WhatsApp groups and the family's smartphone) rather than building our own or distributing hardware.

Geographical Assessment

We chose Hindi partly for fit: one cofounder is fluent, ALfA is used most widely in Hindi, and partner NGO DEVI Sansthan's MoUs cover Hindi-speaking states. Hindi also scores well in our weighted factor model:

- **more illiterate native speakers than any other language**
- **almost 90% of families have a smartphone at home**
- **a highly phonetic script, easier to teach**

In late October we began piloting in two additional states where our partner organisation has a strong field presence, so we can choose where to scale using implementation data, not just desk research. See the live data on usage here.



[2] Our CEA counts only income, following AIM's conservative estimate that each standard deviation of learning raises lifetime earnings by about 10%. It excludes literacy's non-economic benefits, such as fewer child marriages and lower infant mortality.

LONG-TERM PLAN AND ENDGAME

We think LIFTeracy can meet Mulago's three tests for scale.

Big Enough

Over 100 million children have Hindi as their primary language, more than half cannot read by age ten, and 84% of their families have a smartphone.

Simple Enough

LIFTeracy uses existing infrastructure (the family phone and the school WhatsApp group), so officials and teachers only forward a link and follow up on usage.

Cheap Enough

A 5-minute lesson costs has a tech cost of about 2 cents, and costs should fall as speech-to-text improves and becomes cheaper.

Long term, we hope Indian governments will become our payer-at-scale.

Our cost is modest next to existing budgets. Uttar Pradesh's 2026–27 basic education budget is $8.8 billion, roughly $600 for each of the 15 million children in its government schools; LIFTeracy costs just a fraction of this.

State governments already buy EdTech. Andhra Pradesh plans to roll out adaptive learning software for over 2,000 schools; Haryana spent $70 million on tablets with adaptive software; and Karnataka funds and runs Youth Impact's phone tutoring for over 150,000 students.

Upside Potential

We are focused on Hindi literacy in government schools, but if the model works it could grow in several ways:

Helping other charities expand from text-based to voice-based. We will share our open-source codebase and know-how with organisations moving from text to voice, enabling greater reach to low-literacy users.

Replicating for other languages. Other major languages, both Indian (e.g. Bengali, Marathi, Tamil, Telugu) and international (e.g. English, Spanish, Portuguese, Bahasa Indonesia) could reach many more learners.

Adults as well as children. India has about 250 million illiterate adults (2011 Census) – more than the next 10 countries combined – and our small 2025 pilot, mostly with adults, suggests the approach may work for them too.

Tackling education more broadly. The tutor could expand from reading to numeracy, and more broadly, one-on-one AI tutors could widen access to quality education across grades and subjects.





We are excited to partner with you to bring a one-on-one reading tutor to millions of children!

Let's work together to lift children out of learning poverty, giving them the power to shape their own futures.

QUESTIONS? COMMENTS? INTERESTED IN A DEMO? WE'D LOVE TO TALK

Book a meeting →

tom@lifteracy.ai · +91 95658 97842
david@lifteracy.ai · +91 63948 69235

KEY LINKS

- 3-minute demo video
- Live metrics dashboard
- Theory of Change
- Budget
- Cost-effectiveness analysis (Monte Carlo)
- Draft RCT plan
- Research report

Photo credits

Front cover: Oak Jones. Children in Nai Basti, Lucknow, India try out an early version of LIFTeracy. Tom has worked in Nai Basti on community health and education since 2018.
Back cover: Mohan Singh. Government primary school students in Kakori, Lucknow gather around an Academic Resource Person demonstrating LIFTeracy.
Page 9 (both): Tom Delaney. Tom's landlady's son was one of LIFTeracy's early adopters.
All other pages: Mohan Singh. Government school children in Kakori, Lucknow using LIFTeracy. Note that LIFTeracy is intended as primarily an at-home learning tool, but many of the photos in this report were taken during school visits to demo the product with teachers & students. Several of the photos show children playing learning games built in as a reward mechanism.

LIFTeracy
Lifting children out of learning poverty